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### Baseball Potpourri

**THEY LOOKED LIKE** the El Paso Diablos of old, only they wore a different uniform from the familiar yellow and red colors of the Rojos.

Ambling down to the visitor's dressing room at Giants Stadium in Phoenix, the first humble face lingering by his locker was last year's Texas League home run king Willie 'Ack-Ack' Aikens outfitted in Salt Lake City colors.

There was a friendly, relaxed atmosphere around the clubhouse as the Gulls prepared for the second game of the young season after defeating Phoenix the night before 6-2 on the strength of homers by Butch Alberts and Danny Goodwin.

But deep down inside Aikens was a disturbed feeling. Sure he enjoys playing in AAA Baseball where long bus rides no longer exist, where plane rides are a hop, skip and a jump to such lavish places as Hawaii where the Gulls will play May 29.

Aikens isn't satisfied with moving only one notch up the ladder in a single season. It's rightly so that his goals be aimed at the major leagues. In a year's time or less, that goal could be reality.

The disturbing factor to Aikens is California's persistence in buying a championship team when, in Aikens words, "The Angels have the best farm system in the country."

"I don't like it. The Angels pay millions of dollars for guys like Joe Rudi, Bobby Grich and Don Baylor and none of them are batting about .300. It's disappointing to see that happen when you have guys down in the minors who are trying to make it to the majors but can't because California would rather go out and buy their players from other teams.

"The only people that gain from it are the pitchers on the Angels' staff."

Indeed, Aikens has a valid point which would stand up in any court. Unfortunately, there is nothing he or any of the other Salt Lake players can do but spend their time in California's minor league system until either the Angels or possibly another major league club decides to give them the chance they deserve.

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**ARIZONA STATE BASEBALL** fans must rank among the Top 10 in the country as far as expressing their opinions to opposing players and managers.

UTEP suffered through enough hardships on the field as the Sun Devils embarrassed the Miners three times.

What's harder to swallow are the comments which flow from all sides of the stands. ASU Coach Jim Brock's youngest son has even tormented opposing managers with a unique gimmick.

"Wait 'til you see the dead chick Brock's son has tied to a fishing pole," said UTEP senior pitcher Dave Jannusch this past weekend as he made his final trip to what he terms "an ungodly place to play at."

"He'll throw the chicken out by Andy (Cohen) and then reel it back in."

It never occurred this trip.

"I've learned to play along with their games," said the aging Miner coach. "But it's still difficult to get the hell beat out of you and have to take the abuse from the stands."

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**WEDNESDAY MARKS DECISION** Day by the Western Athletic Conference whether to honor ASU Coach Jim Brock's protest of a 2-1 defeat at the hands of New Mexico on April 9.

Arizona State was down by one run in the top of the ninth in Albuquerque and had runners on first and second with one out. ASU's next batter sent a fly deep to centerfield and at the crack of the bat, the runner from first was off.

The runner on second waited to see if the ball would be caught (it wasn't) and he started heading toward third and eventually home.

As the lead runner rounded third, he slipped and fell. Sun Devil Coach Brock helped the runner up which automatically disqualified the base runner.

But as the runner fell, the player which was on first almost passed him and the runners headed toward home almost step-for-step.

The ball was thrown home from center and the first runner who had been called out for interference ran over New Mexico's catcher, pushing him away from the plate and allowing the second runner to score.

The home plate umpire ruled the first runner was out for being interfered with and that the same runner was called for interference at home.

"I admit I was wrong for helping the runner up," said Brock over the weekend. "But once interference is called, you have a dead ball and the runners return to their closest base."

"It's a misunderstanding of the rules and my protest is that we should have runners on second and third with two outs and New Mexico leading 2-1."

If the WAC upholds Brock's decision, the two teams most likely will conclude the game at ASU's Packard Stadium April 29, having the same two runners on their respective bases with the next batter up.

The fate of ASU's season could depend on the outcome of the WAC's ruling. The Sun Devils trail rival Arizona in the conference standings by two games. A favorable ruling plus one timely hit would cut the margin to one game behind the Wildcats and enlighten ASU's chances of repeating as WAC champions.